Advani had discovered similar skills in the young pracharak from Gujarat in the 1980s and had given him his first major break in the party. Advani believed in mentoring young people, and an entire generation of BJP leaders has been nurtured under his tutelage. Modi was one of them. That belief in Modi's abilities had even led him to strongly insist that the Gujarat chief minister be allowed to continue in office after the 2002 riots when Vajpayee had decided to remove him. 'Let's be clear, if there was no Advani, Modi would have lost his chief ministership at the Goa national executive in 2002,' one senior BJP leader affirms. 'Only Advani could have changed Vajpayee's mind that day.'

Now, the BJP's national executive was meeting again in 2013 at the very same Marriott Hotel along Panaji's Miramar Beach. Only this time, the party was preparing to announce Modi as campaign committee chairman for the 2014 elections. Advani's supporters claim he was informed about the plan just twenty-four hours before the executive was to begin. That's when he decided to stay away and boycott the meeting, citing ill health, and virtually forcing a confrontation. 'It wasn't a personal fight with Modi. Advaniji was just upset that as the seniormost BJP leader he hadn't been properly consulted before such a major decision was taken,' claims an Advani insider.

But the public nature of Advani's response suggested otherwise. A day after the Modi announcement was formally made in Goa, Advani announced his resignation from all party posts and shot off a three-paragraph letter to Rajnath Singh, claiming that the party had lost the 'idealism' of Syama Prasad Mookerjee, Deendayal Upadhyaya, Nanaji Deshmukh and Vajpayee. The letter stated: 'For some time I have been finding it difficult to reconcile with the current functioning of the party, or the direction in which it is going . . . Most leaders of ours are now just concerned with their personal agendas.' There was no mention of Modi in the letter, but it was obvious who the target of Advani's ire was.

The letter, leaked almost immediately to the media, embarrassed the BJP just when it was poised to announce its 2014 campaign strategy. It also reignited divisions within the party. A small group, which included Sushma